controlled. The mechanism of type coercion (aka type juggling) was introduced, and we saw how this could lead to problems; we'll explore this in more detail in coming chapters. We also saw how to force PHP to execute code in a far more type-strict way, minimizing the potential for the type-coercion issues we'll see later.

From data representation, we then moved to the fundamental mechanism for storing and manipulating data: variables. Small but deeply important language features that they are. Obviously, you will see a great deal more use of them in the rest of the book, but it will be in the context of other features. They're everywhere, and you can't avoid them, which is the nature of fundamental things. We examined the ways that data types are controlled, both implicitly and explicitly. We also looked at creating and accessing global constants and the various predefined constant and variable data PHP provides for your convenience.